



white photographs of them next to the screens. Here you will find people such as the artist Satish Gujral or India's former prime minister Manmohan Singh talking about their families' experiences during Partition (the more prominent eyewitness accounts, like Singh or Gujral's, are placed in a separate mini-gallery called Inspirational Stories).

The other great strength of this museum is how it connects the Partition narrative to the story of Delhi. At the museum, you'll find gazette notifications, public notices, directives from high governmental offices, all dating from those tumultuous months in 1947. Letters directing police forces to help refugees with food, clothes and other necessities. Tables and charts dividing Delhi into 'zones', with a number next to each zone, indicating the number of expected refugees in that zone. City-level planning documents where we see how the physical structure of Delhi neighbourhoods like Lajpat Nagar and Jangpura changed—once the made-for-refugees establishments had been constructed, that is. The history of this city is inextricable from the history of Partition, whichever way you slice it, and the Partition Museum provides a great starting point from which to understand this connection.

One of the biggest strengths of the Partition Museum is the **sheer diversity of** eyewitness accounts on display

These parts of the Partition Museum work well because they're based on good, old-fashioned museum work. A couple of things didn't work nearly as well for me. One was the VR (virtual reality) film available for viewers, which for me did not add anything new to the experience. Another misfire (in my opinion) was the half-hearted reconstruction of train bogeys in the middle of the museum, supposed to resemble the trains used in the several exoduses of that era.

There's a really loud loudspeaker that's blaring what I can only call 'generic train sounds'. There's the flotsam and jetsam of travel-under-siege: a torn *gamcha* here, a solitary *chappal* there. And, in the middle of this, an anachronism—mini-fans attached to the bogey's ceiling, just like contemporary Indian trains have. Why bother with the reconstruction, then, if you're going to place modern-day fans bang in the centre of the exhibit? It ends up being a case of neither here nor there.

These minor quibbles aside, a visit to the Partition Museum is highly recommended, whether you're a hardcore history buff or a newbie looking to learn more. ■

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philosophical concepts, namely, *Gyan* (knowledge), *Prakriti* (nature), *Aastha* (faith), *Ullas* (joy), *Parv* (festival), *Samrasta* (unity), *Swavlamban* (self-reliance), and *Yatra* (journey).

"I have been working with craftspeople across the country for a long time," says Jaitly. "This was a huge opportunity for me and, funnily, it wasn't very tough. Once I started working on the concept, the idea of the eight parts of Shilp Deergha came within three days or so."

After an initial visual presentation before a parliamentary panel, Jaitly was asked to lead the project. Once the work started, Jaitly and her team found innovative ways to involve artists and craftspeople from across the country.

For example, as Jaitly explains, one of the installations on display is a large patchwork quilt with pieces from around India. "The raw material for this was sent to female craftspeople across the country," says Jaitly. The theme was deliberately simple and broad: expressing the joy of motherhood. As it so happens, several Indian artistic traditions already celebrate motherhood. In Bihar, for example, the Sujani embroidery tradition involves patchwork quilts made out of old clothes and fragments—'sujani' means 'well-born' and the idea was to make a blanket in which the newborn baby is swaddled for the first time.

"The Shilp Deergha has been made possible by the tireless work of thousands of craftspeople," says Jaitly. "The idea is that when parliamentarians look at these installations, they will take that feeling back to their constituencies and perhaps invest in promoting the signature arts or crafts traditions of that constituency." ■

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